

## MODULE 01 / 40

# Northern Cardinal

*Cardinalis cardinalis***QUICK STATS**

|          |                                 |
|----------|---------------------------------|
| Length   | 8.3 – 9.3 in (21 – 23.5 cm)     |
| Wingspan | 9.8 – 12.2 in (25 – 31 cm)      |
| Weight   | 1.5 – 1.7 oz (42 – 48 g)        |
| Lifespan | Up to 15 years (avg. 3 in wild) |

**PRESENTATION**

The Northern Cardinal is one of the most iconic and instantly recognizable birds visiting North American gardens year-round. The brilliant scarlet male, with his dramatic crest and orange-red bill, is among the most photographed birds on the continent. The female, dressed in warm buff-brown with reddish tinges on her crest, wings and tail, is no less elegant. Both sexes remain on their territory throughout winter, bringing color and song to snow-covered gardens when most other species have migrated south.

**HABITAT & RANGE**

The Northern Cardinal thrives across the eastern half of North America, from southern Maine and the Great Lakes south through Florida, and westward to the Great Plains of Texas and Oklahoma. Populations are also well-established in Arizona, New Mexico, and parts of California. Southern Ontario and Quebec host significant breeding populations. The species has expanded its range northward over the past century, likely aided by the proliferation of bird feeders and milder winters. It favors woodland edges, dense shrubby thickets, hedgerows, suburban gardens, and parks with mature trees and dense understory cover.

**DIET & FEEDING**

- Black-oil sunflower seeds — the undisputed favorite
- Safflower seeds — especially attractive to cardinals
- White millet and cracked corn
- Wild berries: dogwood, holly, elderberry, sumac
- Insects and larvae (essential protein during breeding season)
- Fruit: grapes, mulberries, raspberries

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Cardinals are territorial songbirds that maintain year-round home ranges of roughly 2–4 acres. Males fiercely defend their territory through song and, famously, by attacking their own reflection in windows — mistaking it for a rival. They are monogamous and pairs often remain together through multiple breeding seasons. Outside the breeding season, cardinals may gather in loose flocks of up to 70 individuals at abundant food sources. Males frequently feed females during courtship — a behavior called mate-feeding — passing seeds beak-to-beak.

NESTING & BREEDING

Breeding season runs from March through September, with females typically raising 2 to 4 broods per year — one of the highest rates among North American songbirds. The female constructs a cup-shaped nest over 3–9 days using twigs, bark strips, grasses and leaves, lined with fine grasses and hair. Nests are built 1–15 feet above ground in dense shrubs, vines or low trees. Each clutch contains 2–5 eggs (usually 3), pale whitish or greenish with brown speckles. Incubation lasts 11–13 days, performed almost exclusively by the female. Nestlings fledge at 9–11 days and the male takes over their care while the female begins a new nest.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Northern Cardinal is renowned for its rich, loud whistled song — a series of clear slurred notes often described as "cheer-cheer-cheer" or "birdy-birdy-birdy." Both males and females sing, which is unusual among North American songbirds. The female often sings from the nest, possibly communicating food needs to her mate. Cardinals have a repertoire of 16 or more distinct song patterns. Their sharp metallic "chip" call is an alarm note used to warn of predators. Song peaks in late winter and early spring as males establish territories.

CONSERVATION STATUS

|                |               |                   |                     |
|----------------|---------------|-------------------|---------------------|
| IUCN Red List: | Least Concern | Population trend: | Stable / Increasing |
|----------------|---------------|-------------------|---------------------|

With an estimated population of over 100 million individuals, the Northern Cardinal is one of the most abundant songbirds in North America. Its range has expanded northward significantly since the 1900s. It is the official state bird of 7 US states — more than any other species.

FEEDER TIPS

- Best feeder type: hopper feeder or large platform feeder
- Preferred seeds: safflower (squirrels tend to avoid it) and black-oil sunflower
- Cardinals feed most actively at dawn and dusk
- Place feeders near dense shrubs — cardinals prefer cover close by
- Offer a shallow birdbath: cardinals bathe and drink regularly

COLORING GUIDE

| ZONE            | RECOMMENDED COLOR       |
|-----------------|-------------------------|
| Male body       | Vivid red — cadmium red |
| Facial mask     | Deep black              |
| Bill            | Orange-coral            |
| Female body     | Warm sandy brown        |
| Wings & crest ■ | Rusty-red highlights    |
| Eye             | Dark brown, black ring  |

# COLOR ME!

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